



GABY ORAA/REUTERS

U.S. prisoners freed in Venezuela

State Department says release of multiple Americans marks ‘an important step in the right direction’

BY ANDREW JEONG
AND LAUREN WEBER

Multiple Americans detained in Venezuela have been freed by local authorities, the State Department says, the first known release of U.S. citizens since the U.S. military capture of authoritarian President Nicolás Maduro this month.

“We welcome the release of detained Americans in Venezuela. This is an important step in the right direction by the interim authorities,” the State Department said in a short statement sent to reporters Tuesday evening. It did not specify how many Americans were freed.

Officials in Caracas announced last week that they had begun releasing political prisoners, a move they described as a “unilateral gesture” and which was welcomed by President Donald Trump. Trump said Jan. 3 that he would “run the country.”

Delcy Rodríguez, the interim
SEE VENEZUELA ON A14



GABY ORAA/REUTERS

TOP: Family members of detainees sleep outside a prison in Guatire, Venezuela, as they await releases Wednesday. **ABOVE:** Venezuelan journalist and politician Roland Carreño, left, hugs his son Wednesday after Carreño was freed from prison in Guatire.

Trump says Iran has halted killings amid U.S. threat

TROOP MANEUVERS ECHO SUMMER STRIKES

Thousands feared dead in Tehran’s brutal crackdown

BY TARA COPP,
WARREN P. STROBEL
AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

President Donald Trump said Wednesday that “important sources” in Tehran told the U.S. government that the regime has halted its brutal crackdown on protesters, leaving open the question of whether he intends to order military strikes against Iran after repeated warnings.

As violence throughout the country worsened in recent days, the president promised the Iranian people that the U.S. would come to their aid and, as a precautionary measure earlier Wednesday, the Pentagon began relocating personnel and equipment away from key facilities in the region.

But during a White House signing ceremony, with children flanking him in the Oval Office, Trump said Iran had notified Washington it would no longer carry out hangings of protesters. When asked by a reporter if that meant a U.S. military response was now off the table, he said only, “We’re going to watch and see.”

“We’ve been told,” the president said, “that the killing in Iran is stopping.”

The Washington Post could not independently verify the president’s assessment.

The regime in Tehran has directed a brutal crackdown in
SEE IRAN ON A12

Iran’s opposition: Divisions within ranks hobble push for change. **A12**

Meeting on Greenland ends in ‘disagreement’

Foreign ministers hosted by Vance at White House say little consensus so far

BY ADAM TAYLOR
AND MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

Denmark’s foreign minister said there had been a “frank but also constructive” conversation with the Trump administration during a high-stakes White House meeting about the fate of Greenland on Wednesday, but that the two sides had come to no agreement about President Donald Trump’s demands to “own” the Arctic territory.

“We still have a fundamental disagreement,” said Lars Lokke Rasmussen, the top Danish diplomat, speaking alongside his Greenlandic counterpart, Vivian Motzfeldt, outside the Danish Embassy in Washington. “We

didn’t manage to change the American position.”

The White House meeting, which was hosted by Vice President JD Vance, did see the two sides agree to form a “high-level working group” to discuss Trump’s concerns about Greenland, Rasmussen said. The White House and State Department did not immediately provide their own readout of the meeting, which was also attended by Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

Trump told reporters after the meeting that he had not yet been briefed on the talks, but said that the United States had a good relationship with Denmark and he thought something would work out. “The problem is there’s not a thing that Denmark can do about it if Russia or China wants to occupy Greenland, but there’s everything we can do,” he said in the Oval Office.

The governments of Denmark and Greenland, a self-governing
SEE GREENLAND ON A15

Post journalist’s home is searched in FBI probe

Pentagon contractor is focus of warrant; action decied as ‘outrageous’

BY PERRY STEIN
AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

The FBI executed a search warrant Wednesday morning at a Washington Post reporter’s home as part of an investigation into a government contractor accused of illegally retaining classified government materials.

The reporter, Hannah Natanson, was at her home in Virginia at the time of the search. Federal agents searched her home and her devices, seizing her phone, two laptops and a Garmin watch. One of the laptops was her personal computer, the other a Post-issued laptop.

The Post also received a subpoena Wednesday morning seeking information related to the same government contractor, ac-

cording to a person familiar with the law enforcement action. The subpoena asked the Post to hand over any communications between the contractor and other employees.

It is exceptionally rare for law enforcement officials to conduct searches at reporters’ homes. Federal regulations intended to protect a free press are designed to make it difficult to use aggressive law enforcement tactics against reporters to obtain the identities of their sources or information.

In an email to The Post’s newsroom, Executive Editor Matt Murray called the search an “extraordinary, aggressive action” that is “deeply concerning and raises profound questions and concern around the constitutional protections for our work.”

Investigators told Natanson that she is not the focus of the probe. The warrant said that law enforcement was investigating Aurelio Perez-Lugones, a system administrator in Maryland who has a top-secret security clearance
SEE SEARCH ON A8

U.S. to halt processing of immigrant visas for people from 75 countries

State Dept.: Pause aims to limit applicants likely to rely on public benefits

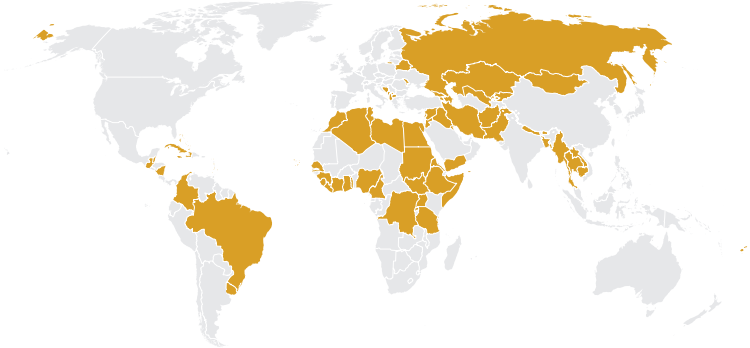
BY ADAM TAYLOR
AND DAVID NAKAMURA

The Trump administration is halting immigrant visa processing for people from 75 countries, including Brazil, Iran, Russia and Somalia, the latest effort by officials to restrict legal immigration pathways.

State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott said the indefinite pause aims to limit applicants deemed likely to become a “public charge,” a term for someone who relies on government benefits for their basic needs. The order takes effect Wednesday, and a full list of the countries on the administration’s list has not been released.

“The Trump administration is bringing an end to the abuse of America’s immigration system by

Countries affected by visa processing pause



As of Jan. 14

Source: U.S. official

NICK MOURTOUPALAS/THE WASHINGTON POST

those who would extract wealth from the American people,” Pigott said.

The State Department has ramped up efforts in recent months to restrict migration, particularly from nations the president has deemed a threat to national security. Last month, the administration expanded a full or partial travel ban on entry to the United States to citizens of 39

countries, a move that came after an Afghan immigrant was charged in the shooting in November of two National Guard members in D.C.

The administration also paused all asylum cases processed by U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services, suspended processing of citizenship and green card applications for citizens of the initial 19
SEE VISAS ON A4

As boomers dig in, Gen Z is finding job market a slog

BY TAYLOR TELFORD

Since graduating from Barnard College of Columbia University in 2024, Menasha Thomas has learned to navigate the swirl of networking and referrals, online job-search groups and interview processes. But after 14 months of soldiering through scores of applications, the 23-year-old has yet to put her urban planning degree to use in a full-time job.

In the meantime, she took professional certification and real estate courses to make herself more hireable while working as a nanny and at New York City cafes. It has been challenging but not “entirely isolating,” she said, because she knows many other recent grads also are struggling to get started professionally. She recently landed a paid internship with a real estate company, for
SEE AGE ON A20

IN THE NEWS

Phase 2 in Gaza White House envoy Steve Witkoff said the next stage of a 20-point peace plan has begun, with a Palestinian group set up to manage the Strip. **A15**

Va. double-murder trial A woman testifying against Brendan Banfield once wrote that she would “never do anything to hurt” him. **B13**

THE NATION
RFK Jr. added to a vaccine panel two medical professionals who have criticized shots. **A3**
Federal grants that support mental health and addiction care have been slashed. **A8**

THE WORLD
A city in southern Russia is experiencing power grid attacks that are common in Ukraine. **A11**
Over 30 people were killed in Thailand after a construction crane fell onto a moving train. **A14**

THE ECONOMY
In a survey, 1 in 5 families said they face child care hardships because of cost, with single mothers hit hardest. **A16**
The parent company of Saks Fifth Avenue filed for bankruptcy protection after missing an interest payment of \$100 million. **A16**

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The Smithsonian submitted files to the White House, which had threatened to withhold its funding. **B1**

SPORTS
The Nationals will partner with MLB to broadcast their games, ending a rocky run with cable outlet MASN. **B7**

THE REGION
Ruby Corado, founder of the nonprofit Casa Ruby, was sentenced to 33 months for misusing pandemic funds. **B13**

LOCAL LIVING
Consider our roundup of a dozen of-the-moment hobby ideas, if for no other reason than to get off your phone.

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